

Excerpted from Main Problems in American History v. one
Quint, Albertson and Canto

THE WAR OF 1812 was insignificant from a military point of view. Its armies were small, its casualties comparatively few; and even in its own day, it was overshadowed outside America by the climax of the Napoleonic wars in Europe. Yet, American historians have given a disproportionate amount of attention to the events leading up to the war. This interest has stemmed both from its importance in our national development and from disagreement over its causes. That disagreement over causation has occurred is not surprising. Historians, like nations, seldom agree on the causes of a war; and in this century, they have produced a variety of explanations as to why the United States found it necessary to engage in hostilities with England in June, 1812.

Nineteenth-century historians generally held that the United States went to war in 1812 in response to repeated British infringements of American maritime rights...Over the course of years, American forbearance had worn extremely thin. Consequently, it seemed logical to nineteenth-century historians, as well as to some in this century, that only resort to arms in 1812 could protect and maintain the national honor.

This purely maritime explanation of the war has been repeatedly questioned since the 1920's. One apparent inconsistency that gave pause to historians lay in the fact that the strongest opposition to the conflict was in New England, the main commercial and shipping area. If the war was fought to preserve American maritime rights, why should it have been opposed there? And, on the contrary, why did so many leaders of the war party come from the South and from the Mississippi Valley? These doubts produced various "western" interpretations of the causes of the war.

One western interpretation has gained little acceptance by historians who have specialized in the history of the war, though obtaining some currency in general textbooks. This view suggests that in 1812, western Congressmen demanded war because they coveted the rich agricultural lands of Canada. Most historians today would agree that with abundant land available on the American frontier, there was little reason for frontiersmen to risk war with England for still more land in Canada. Yet, though this interpretation has been substantially rejected, it has been argued that the war might be viewed as part of the tradition of "Manifest Destiny," the American attempt to expand over the North American continent in the nineteenth century. The most stimulating and influential of the western interpretations of the war stemmed from the publication in 1925 of Julius W. Pratt's Expansionists of 1812. A vital factor in the coming of the war, Professor Pratt argued, was the western demand that the British be expelled from Canada to prevent them from encouraging the Indians to attack American frontier settlements. He also maintained that this western demand for Canada was matched by a southern desire to annex the Floridas for agrarian, commercial, and strategic reasons. According

to this theory, northern and southern Republicans reached an understanding that acquisition of Canada be balanced by that of the Floridas. Professor Pratt stated that he intended to examine only one aspect of the causes of the war, but historians subsequently have given great weight to his interpretations. It is argued that had maritime oppression sufficed to produce a war, one would have resulted before 1812, and therefore a joint demand for Canada and the Floridas played a decisive role.

Though historians since the 1920's have frequently directed their attention to western and southern pressures for the War of 1812, they have not deserted maritime interpretations. One group has attempted to demonstrate why the West and the South should have supported a war fought for maritime reasons. It holds that the roots of the war lay in the problems of agricultural depression and foreign markets. Although many New Englanders were prepared to lose men, ships, and honor to gain the rich profits of the carrying trade, the South and the 'Vest found common cause in the agricultural depressions which beset them. Their natural inclination was to blame this depression on British commercial restrictions. 'When all other alternatives failed, they demanded war as the only way to break the commercial stranglehold

More recently, most historians have tended to avoid either strictly sectional or expansionist interpretations and to emphasize maritime factors. Yet, no general agreement prevails. One view holds that the war stemmed from an effort to preserve the national honor, compromised by events since the Revolution-in short, a desire to maintain America's integrity as a nation and to vindicate the years of insult and national shame.